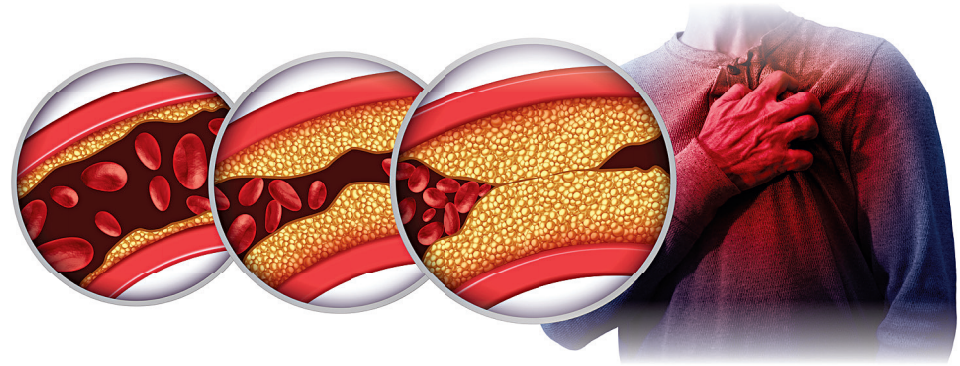




HEART CARE ESSENTIALS POST THE FIRST ATTACK

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Healthy heart is central to overall good health. The organ in our body which gives us the real meaning of being alive is our heart. People can, at times, be brain dead and yet be considered 'alive'. Heart diseases come under the category of non-communicable disorders: they do not transmit from one person to another. Among the many causes of death, heart ailments stand at the number one position. The WHO estimates that around 18 million people die of cardiovascular diseases every year, accounting for over 32% of global deaths. One-third of these deaths are premature. About 85% of all CVDs manifest themselves as heart attacks or strokes and more than 75% of cases come from low and middle-income countries. National Doctor's Day is an opportunity to create awareness about cardiac arrest and heart care essentials post the first attack.

The very idea of cardiac arrests or what is more commonly understood as heart attacks are a way of conveying a rather unnerving message every time the topic surfaces. A life threatening medical condition, heart attack is characterized by a sudden blockage in the flow of the blood that reaches the heart. As a result, surrounding tissues are subjected to instant damage, thereby harbouring severe consequences to the patient's health, in some cases, even proving fatal to him. There have been numerous technological advancements in Cardiology in India and with new advancements in technology for treating artery blockages in the heart, it is advisable to use drug eluting stents (DES) which are well studied in a broad spectrum of patients across countries and have large clinical data of patients. The latest generation Platinum Chromium stents helps in optimizing PCI results and provide better patient outcome.

The path to recovery is tough, but how to approach and deal with the condition post-attack, understanding what to do after a heart attack and adherence to the proper rehabilitation routine can significantly reduce the chances of another heart attack. Most people can go home after about three to five days in the hospital. In some cases, the hospital stay could be longer especially if you had surgery. If you develop complications, you will be kept under observation until your condition is stable. Before leaving the hospital, it is important for you and your family to understand the discharge plan. Make sure all your questions are answered and get written directions for taking all your medications. After a heart attack, it is common to start new medications and stop or adjust the doses of old medications. On average, most patients have to take a regular dosage of medicines that helps correct hypertension, chest pain, diabetes, high cholesterol, and body weight issues. Participation in a cardiac rehabilitation program is designed to improve your heart health through medically supervised exercise training, diet education, and other risk management. It also teaches how to deal with stress, so it can help prevent post-heart attack depression and anxiety. After a heart attack, you will want to go back to your regular life. However, that depends on your work, recreation, and sexual activity as well as the condition of your heart. Start slowly to give your heart a chance to heal. Your doctor will tell you when you can be active again and what you should do. Do not exercise without talking to your doctor first. Regarding going back to work, the amount of time you are off from work varies. It depends on your heart health and how active and stressful your job is.

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There are steps you can take to recover from a heart attack and prevent another one. This is known as "secondary prevention." First, understand your type of heart disease. Your doctor will tell you the risk factors and how to prevent future damage to your heart. You will need to follow a certain healthy lifestyle. If you are a smoker, tobacco user you stand a major risk factor for heart disease. Nicotine, the main chemical in tobacco, raises blood pressure. If you smoke, ask your doctor for a plan to quit. High blood pressure puts stress on your heart and blood vessels. Talk to your doctor about ways to manage your blood pressure. This includes exercising, a diet low in salt, and losing weight if you are overweight. Too much "bad" cholesterol increases your risk of heart disease. Your doctor will prescribe medications to keep cholesterol levels in check. You also should eat a heart-healthy diet and start an exercise program. Diabetes increases your risk of heart attack and stroke. Talk to your doctor about getting screened for diabetes. Regular cardio exercise can make your heart stronger. Examples include walking, jogging, running, bicycling, and swimming. The food you eat affects your blood flow. Add foods to your diet that are low in cholesterol and saturated fats. Eat more fruits and vegetables. Eat less red meat and more white meat and fish. Consume fewer high-fat dairy products. Cut down on salt (sodium) and sugar. Avoid fried and processed foods. Treat your heart right, do your part, and care for your heart. Live healthily, and stay young at heart.